

Using Reflective Practice to Inform Personal and Professional Development

Lesson 2



Working with Reflective Practice Frameworks

Self-awareness

**Emotional
intelligence**

**Popular
frameworks**

Developing Our Self-awareness

In the last lesson, we looked at the foundation of personal development as expanding our discovery about our character and capabilities – that is, who we are and what we can do.

Part of this is self-awareness, defined as having a conscious knowledge of our strengths, weaknesses, motivations, beliefs and emotions.

Author Chris Rose argues that we often fail to develop an accurate perception of ourselves, so every plan for personal development must begin with an accurate investigation of our personality, and exercises in self-awareness. This is a form of reflective practice.

Carrying Out Self-assessment

However, psychologist Jessie Zhu says that ‘self-awareness goes beyond accumulating knowledge about ourselves: it’s also about paying attention to our inner state with a beginner’s mind and an open heart.’

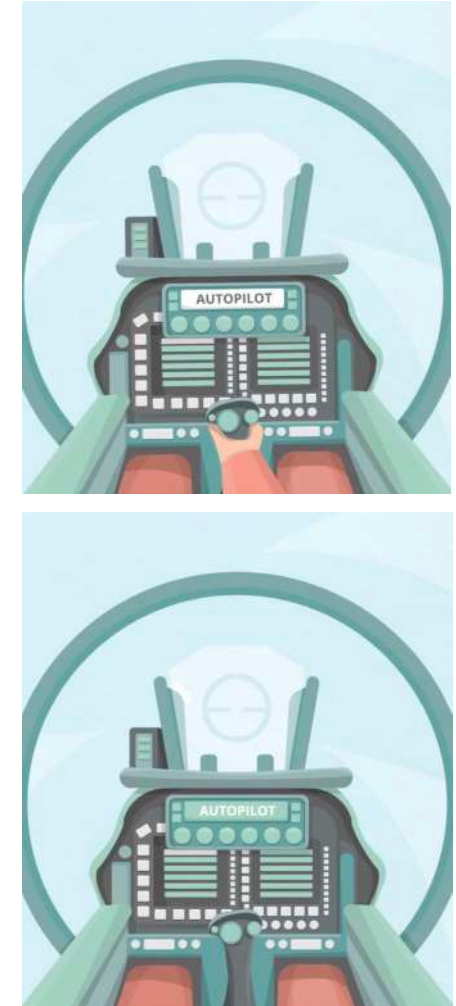
This suggests that carrying out self-assessment within reflective practice only really works if you’re completely honest about your strengths and limitations.



Operating on Autopilot

Self-awareness is not our default mindset. In fact, research has suggested that most of the time, we operate on 'automatic pilot', not giving a thought to what we're doing or how we're feeling in the here and now.

The report 'Autopilot Britain' found that 61% of respondents stick with safe patterns or are too busy to notice decisions they make, such as taking the same route to work each day. And almost half of people reported saying 'yes' four times a day, when they would rather say 'no' - for example, when agreeing to work late.



Developing Emotional Intelligence

One way to improve self-awareness is by developing emotional intelligence. This is defined as the ability to identify, assess and control one's own emotions, and respond appropriately to the emotions of others.

Understanding your own emotions will not only help you to understand why you behave as you do, it will also help you to more accurately interpret other people's behaviour.

Goleman's Components of Emotional Intelligence

Prominent author Daniel Goleman is most commonly associated with emotional intelligence. In 1998 he published a theory of emotional intelligence as a set of five competence and skill components. Goleman saw these as the foundation of management performance at work.

Let's look at each of the components in turn.

Self-awareness and Self-regulation

First is **self-awareness**, which Goleman saw as the cornerstone of emotional intelligence. It's not just about recognising your own emotions and their effects, but also acknowledging your capabilities, gaining self-respect and building self-confidence.

Secondly is **self-regulation**, which is about managing or redirecting disruptive emotions or impulses, and includes self-control, adaptability and trustworthiness.

Motivation, Empathy, and Social Skills

Thirdly, **motivation** concerns having clear goals and a positive attitude, and showing commitment.

Fourth is **empathy**, which is about recognising how other people feel, by putting yourself in their shoes - particularly when making decisions.

Finally, **social skills** are people skills. They include influence, communication, leadership and conflict management, and can be used together to move people in the right direction.

The Five Components

Goleman argues that these five components are not innate abilities, but that each can be learned and developed.

While the concept of emotional intelligence is not without its critics, an article published in The Harvard Business Review in 2011 hailed it as one of the most influential business ideas of the decade.

Setting Time Aside

There's no escaping the fact that better understanding yourself and your emotions takes time – something many of us struggle to set aside. But as managers engage in so many interactions with other people every day, time spent better understanding emotions will be well spent.

Let's look at an example.

Applying Goleman's Components - Example

Ian, an estate agent, is trying to put into context what happened to him recently.

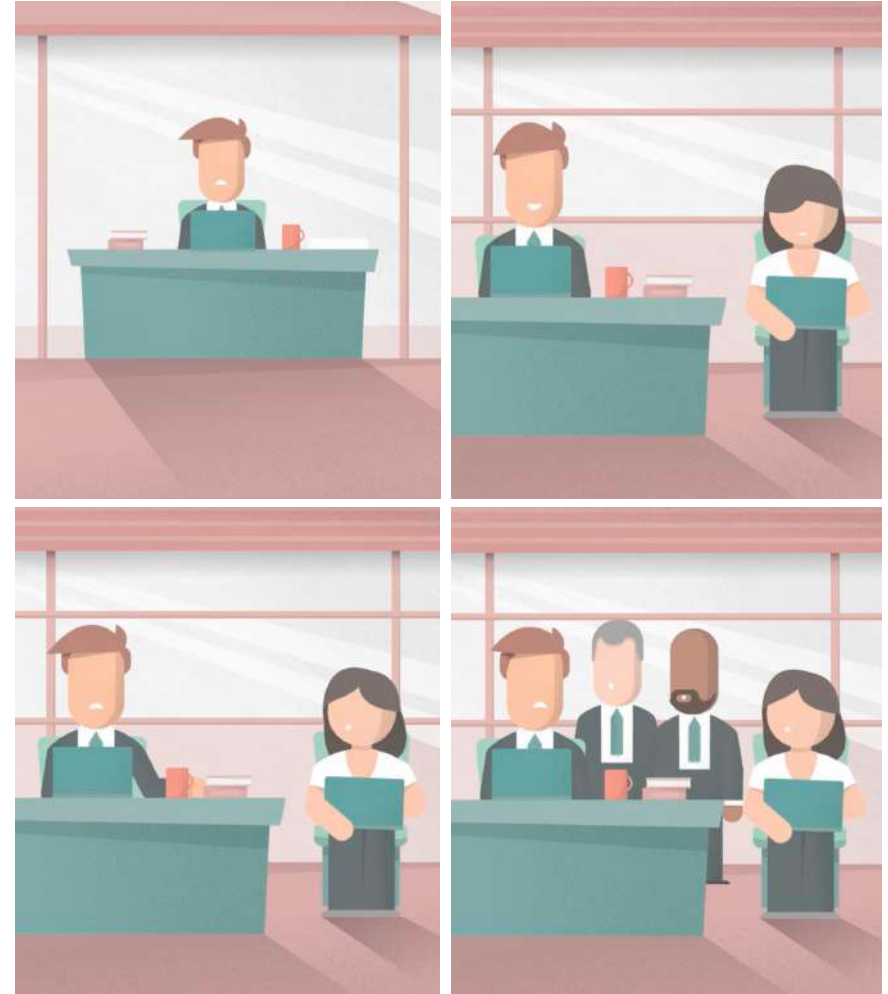
His agency had a cost-saving restructuring programme, and one of the outcomes was the closure of its smaller office and the creation of a shared workspace in the larger one. The traditional office arrangement was turned into hot-desking.



Applying Goleman's Components - Example (cont.)

As a long-time employee, Ian always had his own personal desk by the window in the smaller office. He strongly protested against the new arrangements and, on the day of the move, he commandeered one of the hot desks by laying out his things on it.

A new colleague, who was trying to balance a laptop on her knee, suggested that he share with her, as he would be out visiting properties most of the day. But Ian became angry and told her that he was there first and needed his personal space. It caused quite a commotion in the office, with other people getting involved in the dispute.



Applying Goleman's Components - Example (cont.)

Looking back, Ian realises he didn't display Goleman's five components of emotional intelligence. He didn't self-regulate by adapting himself to the new office arrangements, and he showed a lack of empathy for his colleagues by choosing not to share his desk.

However, by consciously reflecting on events and reviewing the experience from different perspectives, Ian can consider why things happened as they did, why other people behaved the way they did, and how he might proceed next time.

Frameworks to Structure Your Reflection

So far, we've identified the value of being self-aware and emotionally intelligent, and how reflective practice can help develop this type of self-knowledge.

For the remainder of this lesson, we're going to turn our attention to some popular frameworks that you can use to give structure to your reflective practice.

These frameworks illustrate that looking back on an event should be a systematic process, and that learning is not just about thinking, but, most importantly, about doing.

John Dewey and Problem Resolution

Reflective practice is not a new concept. In fact, as early as the 1930s, US philosopher John Dewey recognised it as a specialist form of thinking that could stem from doubt, hesitation and perplexity, relating to an experienced event.

He saw reflective practice as a form of problem resolution, where one could use the process to question knowledge that was taken for granted, and think out a problem using trial-and-error testing.

Reflection in Action

Dewey's idea of reflective practice gained influence through Donald Schön, whose 1983 seminal work, *The Reflective Practitioner*, proposed two forms of reflective practice.

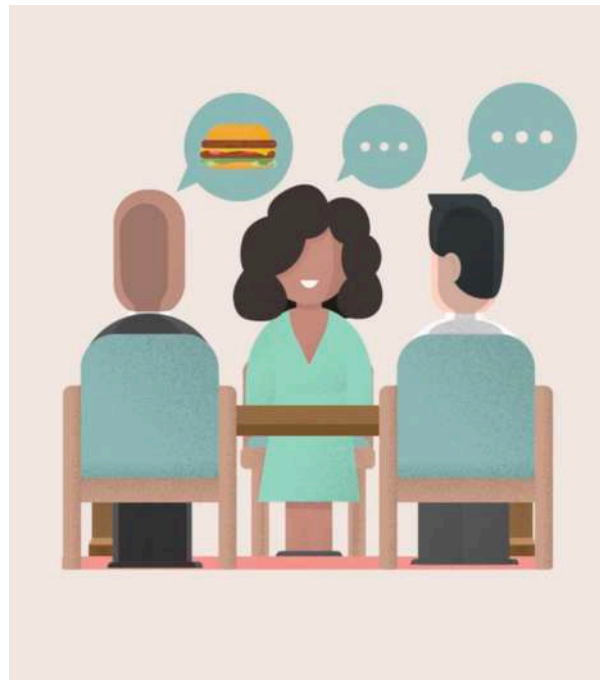
The first form is 'reflection in action', which Schön defines as "where we may reflect in the midst of action without interrupting it. Our thinking serves to reshape what we are doing while we are doing it."

In simpler terms, it's about thinking on your feet and acting straight away.

Reflection in Action (cont.)

For example, a meeting you are running departs from the agenda and you must decide – in the moment – what action to take to regain focus.

Here, you consider the situation, decide how to act, then act immediately.



Reflection on Action

The second form of Schön's reflective practice is 'reflection on action', which entails revisiting a past experience from the safety of the present, in order to learn from it.

Here, you reconstruct the situation and think about what needs changing for the future. This allows for new information or perspectives to be considered, along with a separation from any emotions which might have influenced the situation at the time.

Schön's approach to reflective practice provides us with a framework for thinking, but doesn't offer a step-by-step approach, whereas the next model does.



The Cycle of Experiential Learning

Following Schön, educational theorist David Kolb presented his own approach to reflective practice, in 1984.

He looked for a way to capture how we might learn from our experience and make sense of it, in order to develop and improve professional practice.

To do this, Kolb developed a model which he called The Cycle of Experiential Learning. It is made up of four distinct stages, which we will look at now.

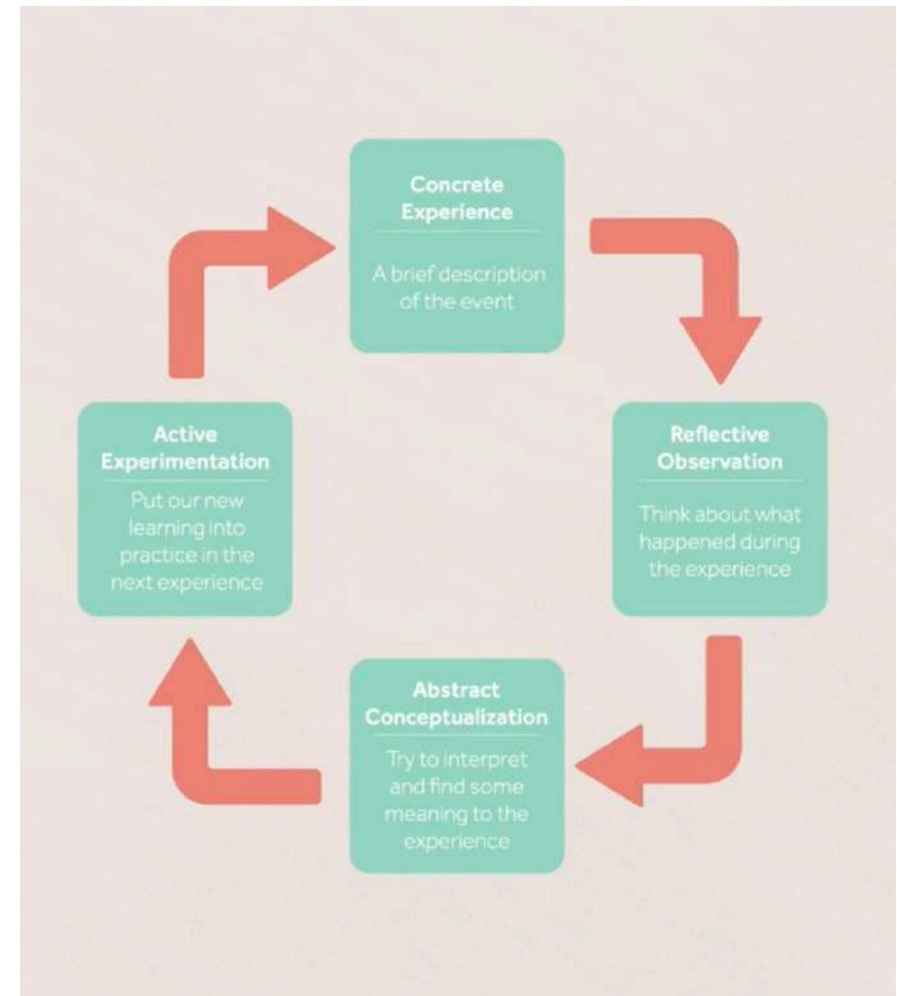
The Cycle of Experiential Learning (cont.)

First, **Concrete Experience**; this is a brief description of the event.

Second, **Reflective Observation**; here, we think about what happened during the experience.

Third, **Abstract Conceptualisation**; now we try to interpret and find some meaning to the experience.

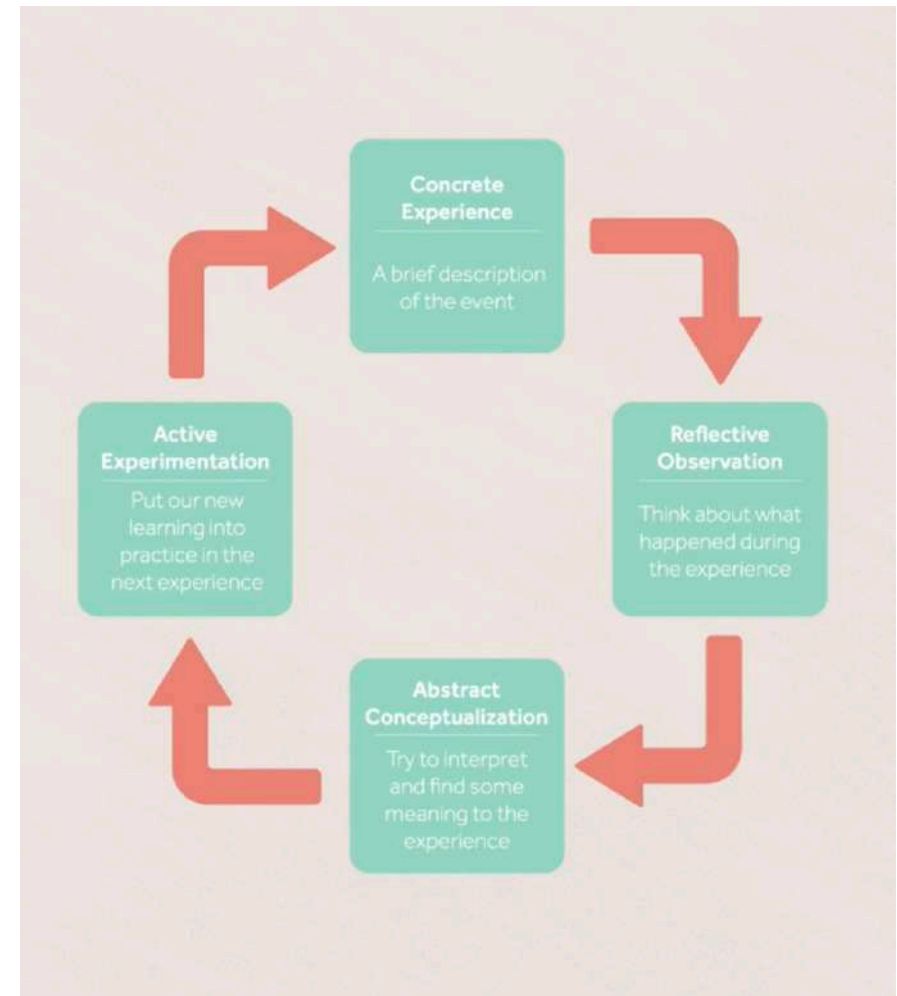
Lastly, **Active Experimentation**; this is where we put our new learning into practice in the next experience.



The Cycle of Experiential Learning (cont.)

Each of the four stages has a particular activity and function that is essential for the achievement of learning.

Kolb stated that to learn from our experiences it's not sufficient just to have them: this will only take us into stage one of the cycle. Rather, we must pass through all stages by reflecting on our experiences, interpreting them and testing our interpretations.



Applying the Cycle of Experiential Learning - Example

Let's look at each of these stages in more detail, using the example of Alison, a reception manager at a busy 5-star hotel.

She has recently had a difficult conversation with one of her team members, Nick. This was brought about following comments from the general manager about Nick's overall appearance and attitude.

While Alison's conversation with Nick seemed to start off ok, it quickly worsened, leaving the issue unresolved.



Applying the Cycle of Experiential Learning - Example (cont.)

Concrete Experience: The purpose of the conversation was to discuss the issue with Nick and get him to agree to change his behaviour.

The critical elements of this event were for Alison to set out the facts, conduct the conversation in a professional manner and agree an action plan.

Applying the Cycle of Experiential Learning - Example (cont.)

Reflective Observation: Alison knows that she needs to try to stand back from the event and make sense of what happened. She reflects on what went well and what didn't. She thinks about how she approached the subject and the way she spoke to Nick. She also thinks about how the conversation made her feel and whether the outcome could have been avoided.



Applying the Cycle of Experiential Learning - Example (cont.)

Abstract Conceptualisation: Alison draws some conclusions about what went wrong, and why and how that might influence her future practice. Rather than just react, she makes a conscious plan to do things differently next time. Part of this plan involves learning more about how to handle difficult conversations, and she finds a really useful ACAS guide on the topic.



Applying the Cycle of Experiential Learning - Example (cont.)

Active Experimentation: This final stage is for Alison to 'test' the conclusions she has formed from the earlier stages. She doesn't have to wait for the same type of difficult conversation but can look for other situations that may present similar critical elements - for example a performance management review.

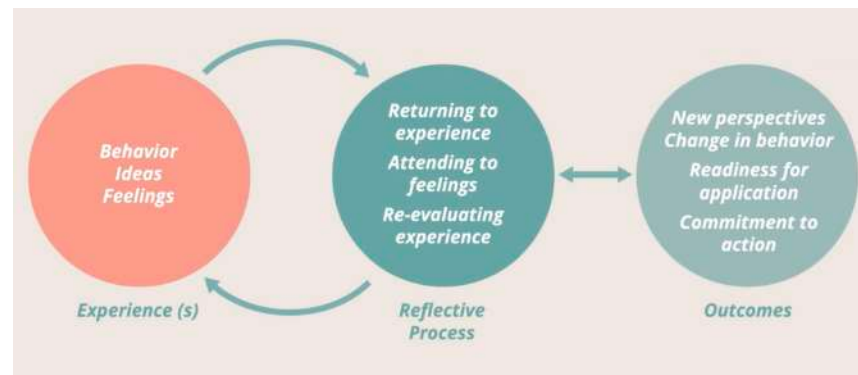
She should also think about any further help she may need, which might involve more reading, some skills training or coaching.

Boud's Model for Reflection

We've just looked at some key thinkers behind reflective practice and explored Kolb's Experiential Learning Cycle.

Next, we are going to examine two further reflective approaches – Boud's model for reflection, and Gibbs's Reflective Cycle.

The first model was developed by academic David Boud and colleagues in 1985. This framework places high value on the emotional element of reflection, by encouraging us to pay attention to our feelings. It's made up of three stages; experience, reflective process, and outcomes, represented as interconnected circles.



Boud's Model for Reflection (cont.)

The circle on the left refers to the Experience, the same as Kolb's first step. Here, you are asked to think about the event – in particular, about your behaviours, ideas and feelings.

In the centre, the Reflective Process requires three types of activity:

The first activity is 'returning to the experience'. This is about re-living the experience in your mind, paying attention to the emotions you felt, and relating it to your own actions and the actions of others.

Boud's Model for Reflection (cont.)

The second activity is 'attending to feelings'. Having acknowledged feelings, you now analyse them. To do this, you might want to ask yourself:

- Why did I feel the way I did?
- How did I react to these feelings?
- What knowledge can help me to understand these emotions?

The third activity is 're-evaluating the experience'. At a later time or date you can be more dispassionate about the experience, perhaps seeing things differently and learning from them. At this point, you should be ready for a change in behaviour or to commit to action.

Boud's Model for Reflection (cont.)

The circle on the right is about Outcomes.

It covers new perspectives on the experience, based on your analysis. You consider what you learned about yourself, how it might have changed your behaviour or practice relating to this experience and beyond, and what you will do next.

Considering Previous Experience

Unlike other reflective frameworks, Boud's model is different in that it shows arrows going back and forth, indicating that the stages can be revisited, rather than just being considered once.

In developing their approach, Boud and his co-authors recognised that previous experience will influence how we engage in a new situation.

For example, past experiences that were positive may create more enthusiasm to learn, whereas when experiences are less positive, we're less likely to repeat them. This reticence to learn might also be influenced by learning habits, keeping us stuck within our comfort zone.

The Value of Reflection

Boud and colleagues also pointed out that how we approach learning counts as well. For example, reflection will not offer the same value if a learner only looks back on a surface level and doesn't wish to find deeper meaning in what they do.

We will be looking at learning habits and styles later in the unit.

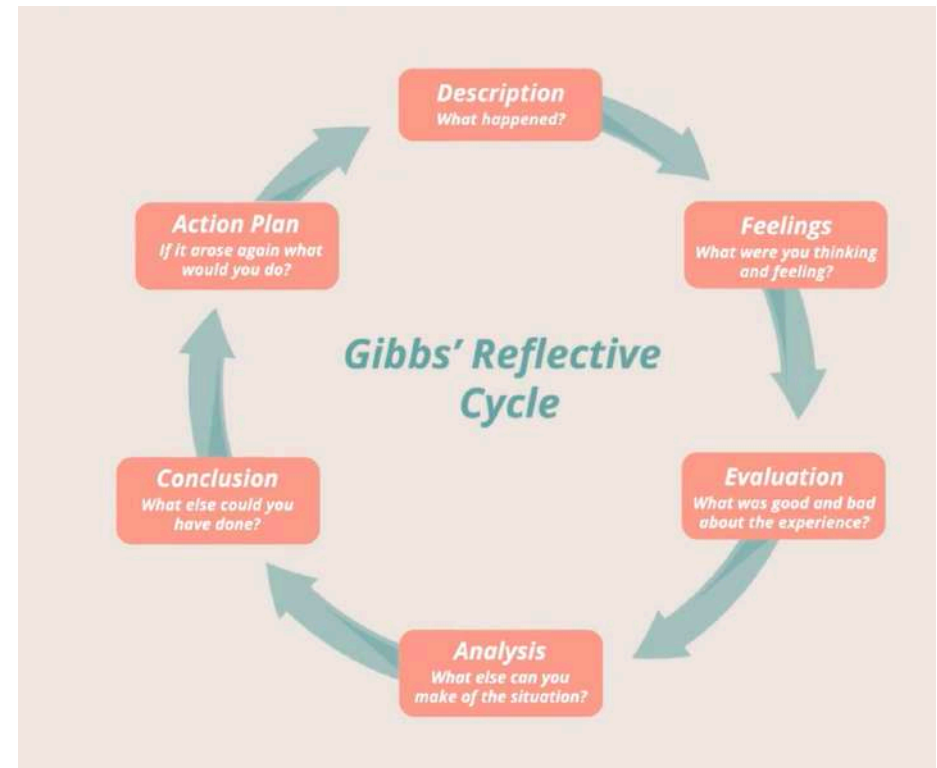
Gibbs's Reflective Cycle

Our next framework is widely used in the healthcare sector and was developed by Graham Gibbs in 1988.

Building on Kolb's Experiential Learning cycle this model is noted for placing particular emphasis on personal feelings.

Gibbs's model is formed of 6 steps. Steps 1 to 3 relate to what happened during the experience. Steps 4 to 6 focus on how you could improve on the experience and outcomes in the future.

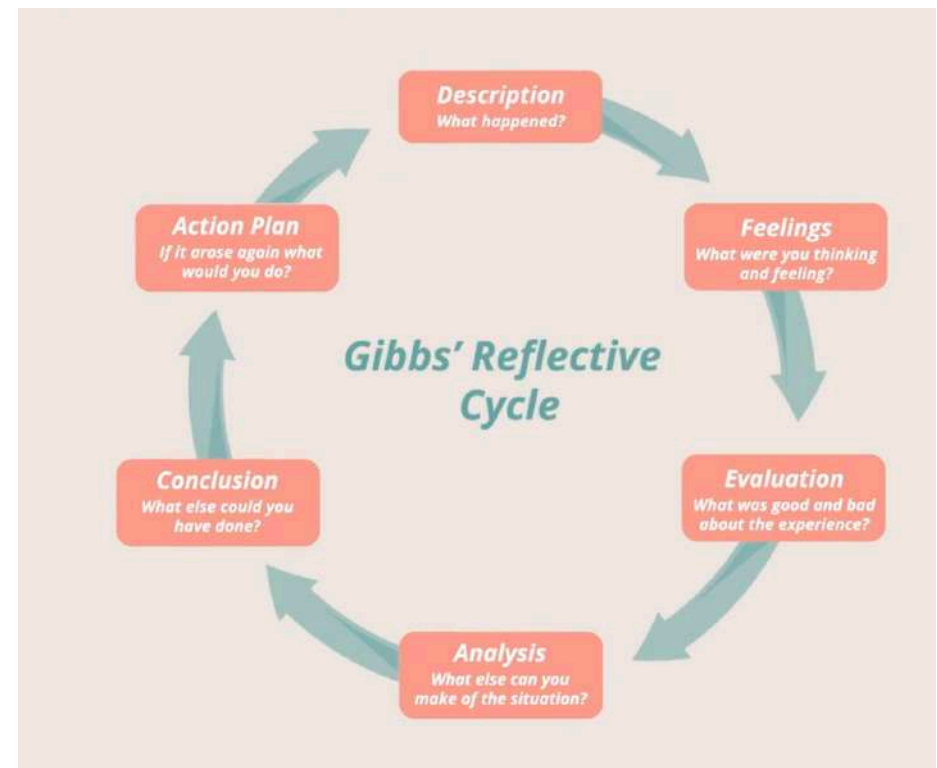
Let's now go through each step in a little detail.



Gibbs's Reflective Cycle (cont.)

Description: This first stage requires a brief account of the experience. In doing so, you should set out the context of the event, explain what you did or didn't do, and outline what happened.

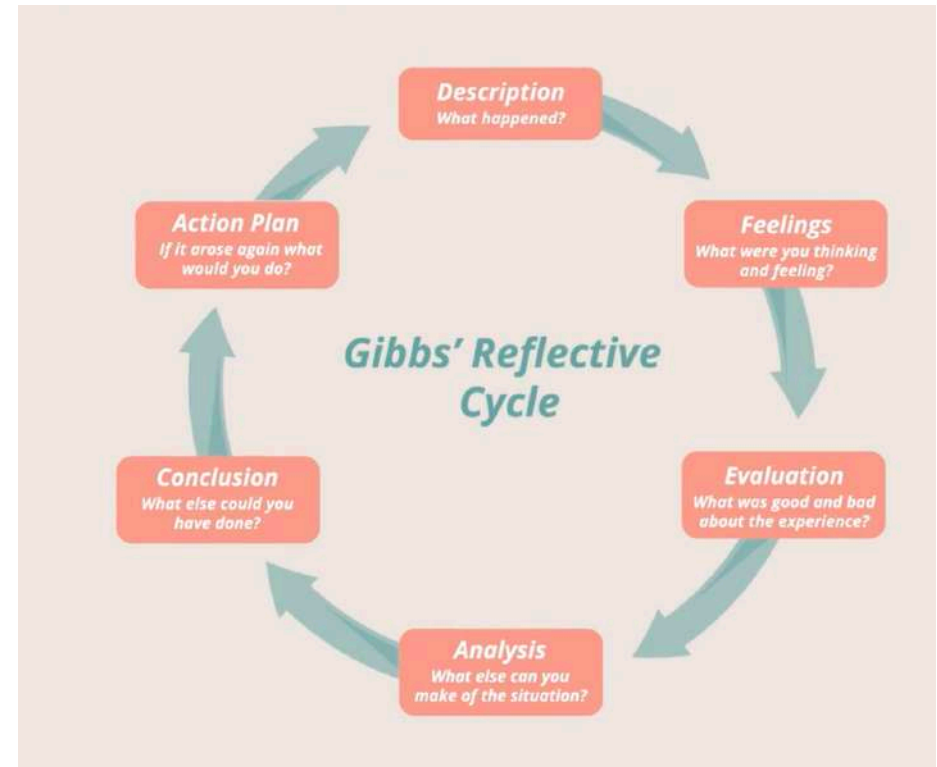
Feelings: Soon into the process, Gibbs asks us to focus on our feelings and our emotional response to the situation. This will include feelings before, during and after the event. This step has been found to be especially helpful for those professionals who might be working in challenging circumstances - for example social work or counselling.



Gibbs's Reflective Cycle (cont.)

Evaluation: Next, we examine what was good about a specific experience as well as what was bad, and consider the underlying reasons. This means that we can look at the positives and build on them. But it also prevents us from dwelling too much on the negatives and running ourselves down.

Analysis: When we get to this stage, we should be trying to make sense of the experience. This might involve looking at it from different perspectives, and considering any assumptions you might have made. It won't always be possible to make sense of all our experiences, but this stage is designed to get you to try.

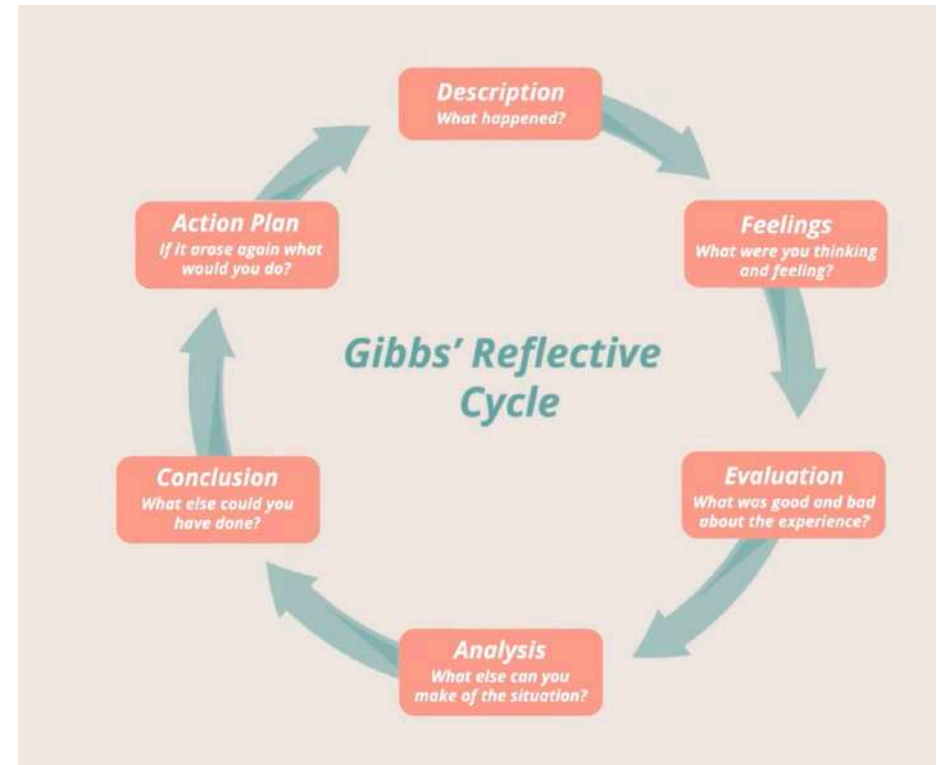


Gibbs's Reflective Cycle (cont.)

Conclusion: Here, you are encouraged to think about what you have learnt about yourself by reflecting on the experience, and what you could or should have done differently.

Action plan: The final stage asks you to think about what you would do if the same situation arose again. Here, you should be focusing on your developmental priorities, and the support that you will need to become better prepared for the future.

With its six distinct stages, this model is easy to use and provides a clear structure for reflective practice.



The Typology of Reflective Practice

Our final framework for reflective practice comes from academic Christopher Johns.

Johns has written widely on reflective practice and you may come across a number of frameworks under his name. We will be looking at The Typology of Reflective Practice, published in 2013.

The Typology of Reflective Practice (cont.)

Like Gibbs's Reflective Cycle, this model was developed for healthcare practitioners. It highlights the importance of knowledge gained through first-hand experience, and the ability of a practitioner to build on this to create new understanding.

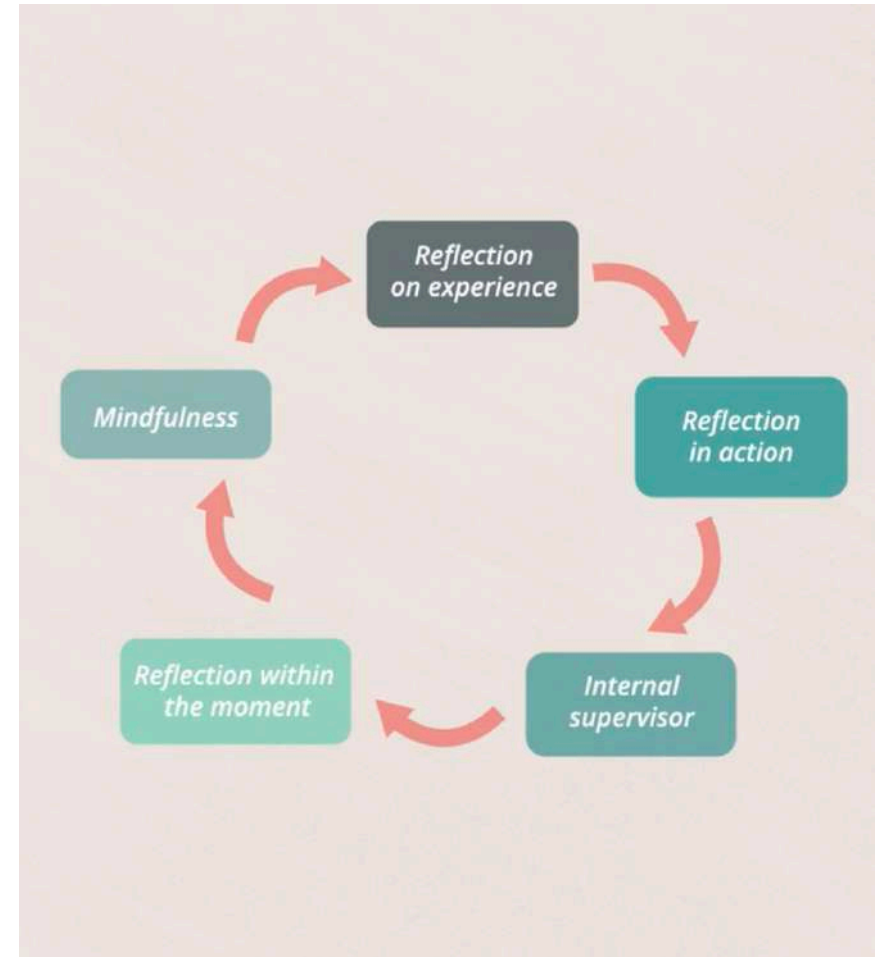
An additional element to the Johns model is that it considers how the practitioner's experience enables them to better understand their context and the options available to them.

The First Stages

According to Johns, there are five stages to this process:

Reflection on experience: Here the practitioner reflects on how a previous experience has informed their practice and can help them in the present.

Reflection-in-action: The practitioner stands back, or 'reframes', during the experience in order to see it differently and make progress towards a desired outcome.

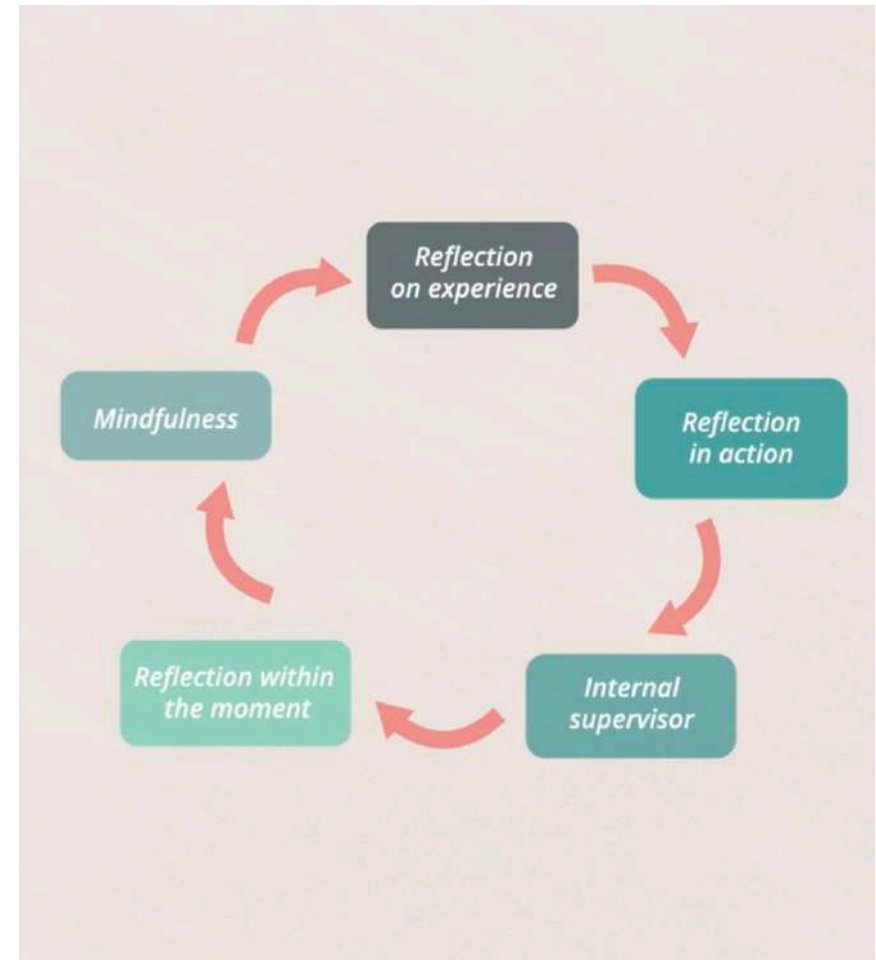


The Final Stages

Internal supervisor: After the experience, the practitioner makes sense of it by going back over the events in their mind and talking them through with another person.

Reflection-within-the-moment: During later experiences, the practitioner is mindful of their patterns of thoughts, feelings and actions, so they can maintain focus on desirable practice.

Mindfulness: Johns describes this as maintaining an awareness of the learning taken from past experiences, but grounding it in the context and reality of new experiences.



The Typology of Reflective Practice - Example

Let's look at an example of how Johns' typology might work in practice.

Jenny is an experienced manager for a short-term shelter for the homeless. The role is very challenging, as there are many more homeless people than beds available.

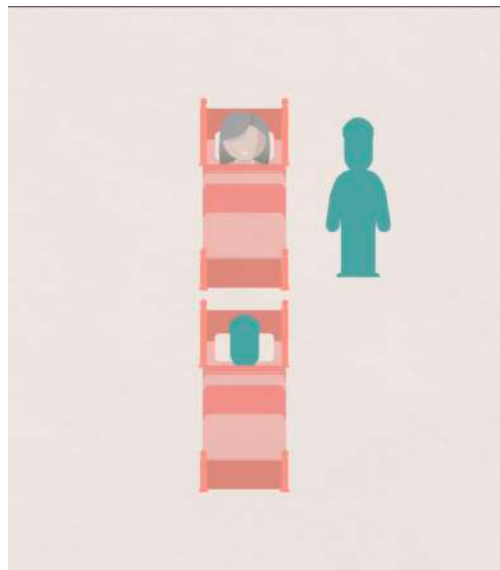
She uses Johns' approach when a frail, elderly woman turns up to the hostel looking for a bed, but there is no space. It's getting late and Jenny has to think on her feet.



The Typology of Reflective Practice - Example (cont.)

Jenny thinks about previous similar situations in reflection on experience. She decides not to send the woman away, but to give her a bed and relocate an existing resident to other accommodation.

During this process, Jenny, is reflecting in action. She considers the situation, decides how to act, then acts immediately.

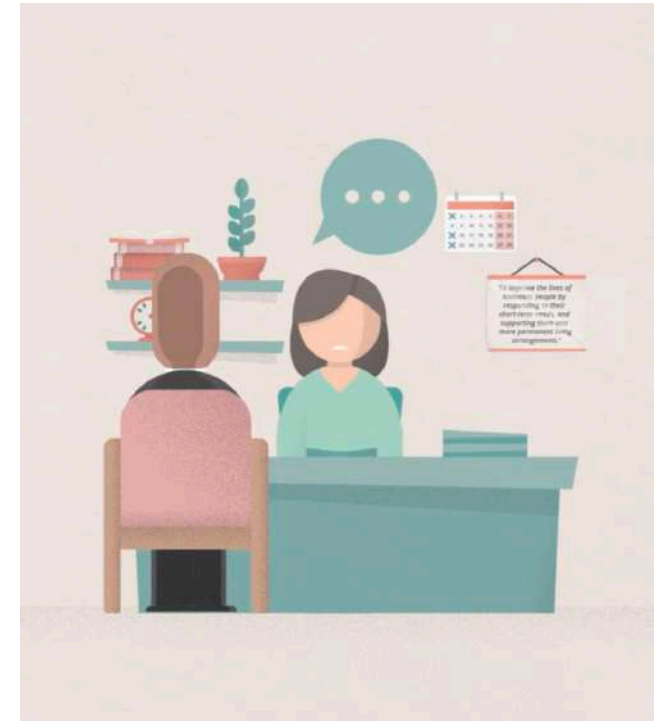


The Typology of Reflective Practice - Example (cont.)

Afterwards, Jenny runs over what happened internally, and shares her thoughts with a colleague, which gives her space to reflect on events. This is the internal supervisor stage and allows her to make sense of the experience.

In the future, Jenny can use what she learned here to reflect within the moment during other experiences, keeping a check on her thoughts, feelings and emotions, and staying focused on how she can perform at her best.

But Jenny will also exercise mindfulness by considering everyone's best interests within the reality of rising homelessness. This helps her to see the limitations of what she can do, and keeps her feet on the ground.



Common Elements of the Frameworks

So, we've learned that reflective practice helps us to improve our self-awareness and there are various frameworks we can apply to structure our approach.

From the popular frameworks covered, we can see that there are some common elements:

- They all require some standing back and making sense of experiences
- They all require us to address our feelings and emotions to a greater or lesser extent
- They should all inform our future professional practice through the new learning they generate

Testing Different Approaches

As reflection is an individual process, there's no one best way of doing it. There is value in testing out the different approaches. The key is to ensure that it's not a theoretical exercise and that you're using an approach that works for you, so that you can learn from your experience.

Once you master the skills of reflection, you can use the practice to support learning across all aspects of your personal and professional life.

In the next lesson, we'll be looking at how you can use reflection to support your development as a manager. We'll also explore some of the self-diagnosis tools that can create greater awareness of how you interact with others around you.

Recap

In this lesson, you have learned about:

- Self-awareness
- Emotional intelligence
- Popular frameworks